

Bài tập thực hành 5

I can put my cash card into an ATM anywhere in the world and take out a fistful of local currency, while the corresponding amount is debited from my bank account at home. I don't even think twice: regardless of the country, I trust that the system will work.

The whole world runs on trust. We trust that people on the street won't rob us, that the bank we deposited money in last month returns it this month, that the justice system punishes the guilty and exonerates the innocent. We trust the food we buy won't poison us, and the people we let in to fix our boiler won't murder us.

[...] Society is an interdependent system that requires widespread co-operation to function. People need to act in ways that are expected of them, to be consistent and compliant. And not just individuals, but organizations and systems.

But in any cooperative system, there is an alternative, parasitic strategy available - cheating. A parasite obtains the benefits of widespread co-operation while at the same time taking advantage of it. There are - and always will be - robbers, crooked banks and judges who take bribes. So how do we ensure that the parasites are kept to a small enough minority to not ruin everything for everyone?

[...] The paradox is that it is in our collective interest to be trustworthy and to co-operate, while it is in our individual self-interest to be parasitic and defect, or cheat. If too many defects, society stops functioning, the crime rate soars, international banking collapses and judicial rulings become available for sale to the highest bidder. No one would trust anyone because there wouldn't be enough trust to go around.

[...] If we can increase the benefits of co-operation or the costs of defection, we can induce people to act in the group interest because it is also in their self interest. These mechanisms have been called societal pressures. A bank's reputation in the community is a societal pressure. So is the lock on the ATM that keeps criminals out.

[...] In reality, there is a complex interplay of societal pressures. The most basic are moral systems regulating our own behaviour. Most of us try not to treat others unfairly because it makes us feel bad and we know they will treat us badly in return. Most don't steal because we feel guilty - and there are consequences when we are caught. We recognize it is in our long-term self-interest not to act in our immediate self-interest.

Morals and reputation worked well enough for primitive lifestyles, but these began to fail as society grew too large. Trust is personal and intimate among people who know each other, and morals and reputation are easily limited to an ingroup. Institutional systems - laws - formalized reputational systems, and security technologies allowed societal pressures to scale up as we expanded into ever-larger groups.

[...] This trust isn't absolute, of course. Not every societal pressure affects everyone equally. Some care more about their reputations, others are naturally law-abiding and still others are

better at picking locks. But the goal isn't total compliance, just to limit the scope for defection. Criminals still target ATMs, and the occasional rogue bank employee steals money from accounts. But for the most part, societal pressures keep defector damage small enough to keep the system intact.

But sometimes the scope is too great, and underlying systems come crashing down. Overfishing has destroyed breeding stocks in many places. Crime and corruption have devastated some countries. The international banking system almost collapsed in 2008. But in general, societal pressures work as a delicate balance between co-operation and defection.

[...] The balance isn't static - technological changes disrupt it all the time. The changes can be related to defecting, so ATM-based 'card-skimmers' make it easier for criminals to steal my codes and empty my bank account. Or they may be related to security, with computerized auditing technology making it more difficult for fraudulent transactions to go through the system unnoticed.

[...] Life becomes dangerous and insecure when new technologies, innovations and ideas increase the scope of defection. Defectors innovate. New attacks become possible. Existing attacks become easier, cheaper, more reliable or more devastating. More people may defect, simply because it's easier to. In response, society must also innovate, to reduce the scope of defection and restore the balance. This dynamic is as old as civilization.

Global banking, terrorists with nuclear weapons, genetic engineering, bio-weapons, pandemics: we now have such dangerous systems that a few defectors can wreak havoc so great that reactive rebalancing might not be enough. Worse still, by the time that society realizes the gravity of the situation, irreversible damage may already have been done.

To add to the complexity, not all defectors are bad. Neither co-operation nor defection relate to any absolute standard of morality. It is defectors who are in the vanguard for change, such as those who helped escaped slaves in the US before the civil war. It is defectors who agitate to overthrow the repressive regimes they live under.

[...] How to achieve the balance is at the core of many of our debates about introducing laws to police the Internet. Anonymity is essential to freedom and liberty and saves the lives of dissidents everywhere. Yet it also protects criminals. Copyright both protects and stifles innovation. [...] The big challenge will be to understand how to simultaneously provide both more societal pressure to deal with the threats of technology, and less pressure to ensure an open, free and evolving society.

Choose the correct letter, A, B, C or D.

We tend to act in a trusting and co-operative way because

- ☐ A. the collective interest is greater than our individual interest.
- ☐ B. group and individual interest are generally equal.
- ☐ C. the consequences of cheating are too great.

- ☐ D. it is in our nature to act in a moral manner.

The writer says that trust is limited because

- ☐ A. it does not include our opinions of the law.
☐ B. we only trust those we are familiar with.
☐ C. it is linked to our personal reputation.
☐ D. it is likely that cheats do not trust anyone.

The examples of overfishing and the problem of the banking system show that

- ☐ A. problems affect both society and the natural world.
☐ B. the system of trust is not reliable.
☐ C. the balance between co-operation and cheating is always at risk.
☐ D. people who cheat the system will sometimes have an advantage.

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